and accused officer comrades of underestimating the opinion of the party: ‘Some officers believed that to strengthen the party’s leading role would weaken the individual performance and discipline in the armed forces.’ He found more sour words for the relationship between officers and rank-and-file servicemen:

There are still officer-comrades who fail to see their enlisted men as class comrades and co-fighters for the cause of socialism and peace on an equal footing with themselves, who pay no attention to their personal needs and troubles and treat them condescendingly even off duty. With the help of our party organisations, we must all quickly rectify this unhealthy state of affairs, which is incompatible with the character of our armed services. At the delegates’ conferences, a number of comrades made the valid criticism that top officers do not always respond to suggestions from the youth groups for improving military training and political work and suppress unfavourable comments on the way they perform their duties. Some officer-comrades were criticised for assuming that while the men can learn from them, they cannot learn anything from the men. During the discussions, several comrades openly posed the question of these officer-comrades’ relation to the party.

Honecker stressed relations between the members of the armed forces and production workers ‘must become closer, even though they have already developed well in the past’. Announcing that many enterprises had delegated members of their staff to the military to maintain close contact with them, he said: ‘This will help to link the members of the armed forces still more closely with socialist construction and help them to handle the